

Cholodenko's *The Kids Are All Right*. Which is why it was good to see Indian films pushing some boundaries too. In 41-year-old Kaushik Ganguly's *Aarekti Premier Golpo*, which was shown in the often radical Panorama section, director Rituparno Ghosh makes a stunning acting debut. He plays a gay documentary film director working on a film on Chapli Babu, or Chapal Bhaduri, a transgender Jatra actor. Their lives intertwine, with their love lines mirroring each other's. Hugely different from the pulp usually churned out by Bengali cinema, the film is somewhat melodramatic yet quaintly charming. As well one supposes shocking, with Indraneil Sengupta, playing a bisexual cameraman, locking lips with Ghosh, who came dressed in character to the premiere in flowing clothes and turban.

Thirty-four-year-old Umesh Vinayak Kulkarni's *Vihir*, (*The Well*) in Marathi, and 38-year-old Laxmikant Shetgaonkar's *Paltadacho Munis* (*The Man Beyond the Bridge*), in Konkani, are examples of filmmakers choosing their own languages to express themselves though they live within Bollywood's radar. As Shetgaonkar said to a nearly full hall after his film, "I wanted to say something to my people though there are only 18 theatres in Goa which host the International Film Festival of India."

CHITTARANJAN GIRI
IN *PALTADACHO
MUNIS*



Paltadacho Munis

Director Laxmikant Shetgaonkar

Only the 7th Konkani film ever about an inter-caste relationship and how it affects a village.

Kulkarni's second film, produced by AB Corp, is a gentle, beautifully shot movie about death and how it affects a boy. The feeling of familial togetherness that pervades the screen could only have come from a cast that knew each other well, which it did, having at various times starred in Kulkarni's shorts made at Pune's FTII. Kulkarni is one among the many resurgent FTIians who have travelled the world with their films and are trying to experiment with style and substance. Another, Abhaya Simha, a filmmaker from Bangalore, was also in Berlin as part of the Goethe Institute's Visitor's Programme, getting ready to make his bilingual

film in Kannada and Malayalam with superstar Mammooty. Shetgaonkar's film, produced by NFDC, a meditative comment on life in a tiny village overrun by caste divisions and religious superstitions, was also well-received, being only the seventh film ever to be made in Konkani.

Both *Vihir* and *Paltadacho Munis* were made at budgets of Rs 1 crore, which is usually what a big Bollywood movie spends on one song. As Kulkarni says, "It takes two years of your life and involves a cast and crew of 100 people. We need bigger budgets." Passion drives them yes, but their pockets should also be full. But the festival was full of little big triumphs, with Indian films participating in the greater good of what Wieland Speck, director of the Panorama section of the festival, called, "lifting carpets, touching taboos". What's more, the films found a market. If *Peepli Live* was sold to the Germans and Polish, *Paltadacho Munis* was sold to the Canadians.

And yes, over 20,000 fans came out in the frozen snow to cheer Shah Rukh Khan, only 5,000 of whom were Indians. Leonardo Di Caprio, who along with his *Shutter Island* director Martin Scorsese, spent over an hour hanging out with Shah Rukh and Karan Johar in their room at the Regent Hotel, would have been jealous.

GIRISH KULKARNI
IN *VIHIR*



Vihir

Director Umesh Vinayak Kulkarni

Marathi film about how the death of a young boy affects his cousin as the family gets together for a marriage.